



STUDY GUIDE

Instrumentals (MUSIC)

Category Overview

The Instrumentals competition celebrates music through instrumental performance and provides musicians with a platform to demonstrate technical command, musical accuracy, expression, creativity and stage presence without the use of vocals.

All types of instruments are permitted, including acoustic, electronic, classical, contemporary and traditional instruments. Participants may perform across different musical styles and genres, and no particular instrument or musical tradition will receive an inherent advantage.

Overview:

- Participants: Solo performances only
- Eligibility: Instrumentalists only
- Instruments: All types of instruments are permitted
- Genres: All appropriate instrumental genres and musical traditions are welcome
- Rounds: Two rounds, with Round 2 serving as the final.

Performance Specifications

- Participants must perform primarily on a live instrument.
- Acoustic, electronic, classical, contemporary and traditional instruments are permitted.
- Backing tracks are allowed in both rounds, including for percussion instruments.
- The participant's live instrumental performance must remain clearly audible and assessable.
- Participants must bring their own instruments unless otherwise communicated by the organising team.
- A sound check will be provided where necessary.

ROUND 1 - Instrumental Skills:

Duration: 2-4 minutes

Participants will perform one instrumental piece of their own choice. This round is designed to test the participant's fundamental command of music and their instrument. Judges will assess tempo, beat, rhythm, melodic accuracy, technical control, tone, dynamics and how accurately and confidently the selected piece is performed.

ROUND 2 - FINAL: Mashup Challenge:

Duration: 3-5 minutes

Finalists will perform a mashup combining two to three songs into one cohesive instrumental performance. The songs may come from the same or different genres. The mashup should demonstrate strong instrumental execution while connecting the selected songs naturally through effective transitions, arrangement, rhythm, melody, dynamics and musical expression. Backing tracks are permitted.



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Judging Criteria:

- Technical Control & Accuracy [10 points]: Accuracy and command of the instrument, including clean execution, coordination, articulation, fingering or sticking technique, and intonation/pitch where applicable.
- Tempo, Beat, Rhythm & Timing [10 points]: Ability to maintain a consistent tempo and beat, execute rhythms accurately, remain in time, and demonstrate rhythmic control throughout the performance.
- Melody & Musical Accuracy [10 points]: Accuracy of the musical material being performed, including notes, melodic lines, patterns, and the participant's ability to preserve the musical identity of the piece or pieces.
- Tone, Dynamics & Articulation [10 points]: Quality and control of sound, including dynamic contrast, accents, attack, sustain, phrasing, articulation, and tonal variation where applicable.
- Musicality, Expression & Creativity [10 points]: Overall musical expression, interpretation, phrasing, and creativity. In the final round, this also includes how effectively the participant arranges and connects the songs within the mashup.
- Stage Presence & Performance Confidence [10 points]: Confidence, composure, posture, command of the instrument, recovery from mistakes, audience connection, and overall performance impact.

TOTAL: 60 POINTS

Note:

1. The decisions of the esteemed panel of judges will be final, binding, and uncontestable under any circumstance.
2. All song selections must feature appropriate lyrics suitable for a school environment. Any song containing explicit, offensive, or inappropriate language and themes will lead to immediate disqualification.